



WORKSHOP MATERIALS

Writing Procedures

Best practices for writing clear, task-oriented procedures and user guides

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AGENDA

What we'll cover

- Task breakdown
- Definition of a procedure
- Anatomy of a procedure
- Practical guidelines for high-quality procedure writing

DISCLAIMER

The following slides assume the Microsoft Manual of Style for Technical Publications as the baseline. Defer to your own team's conventions where they differ.

Organize tasks based on your major workflows

Example outlines showing the task-oriented nature of user guides for a fictional product called Hero Builder:

Getting started with Hero Builder

- About Hero Builder
- Accessing Hero Builder
- Managing your Hero projects
 - Creating a new Hero from template
 - Customizing the Hero's attributes
 - Testing and deploying the Hero
 - Editing existing Heroes
- Managing your Hero library

Setting up and managing a Hero project

- Creating a new Hero project
 - Setting up a standard Hero launch
 - Configuring the Hero project settings
 - Testing and deploying the Hero
 - Managing Hero project changes
- Troubleshooting common issues
- Managing users

DEFINITION

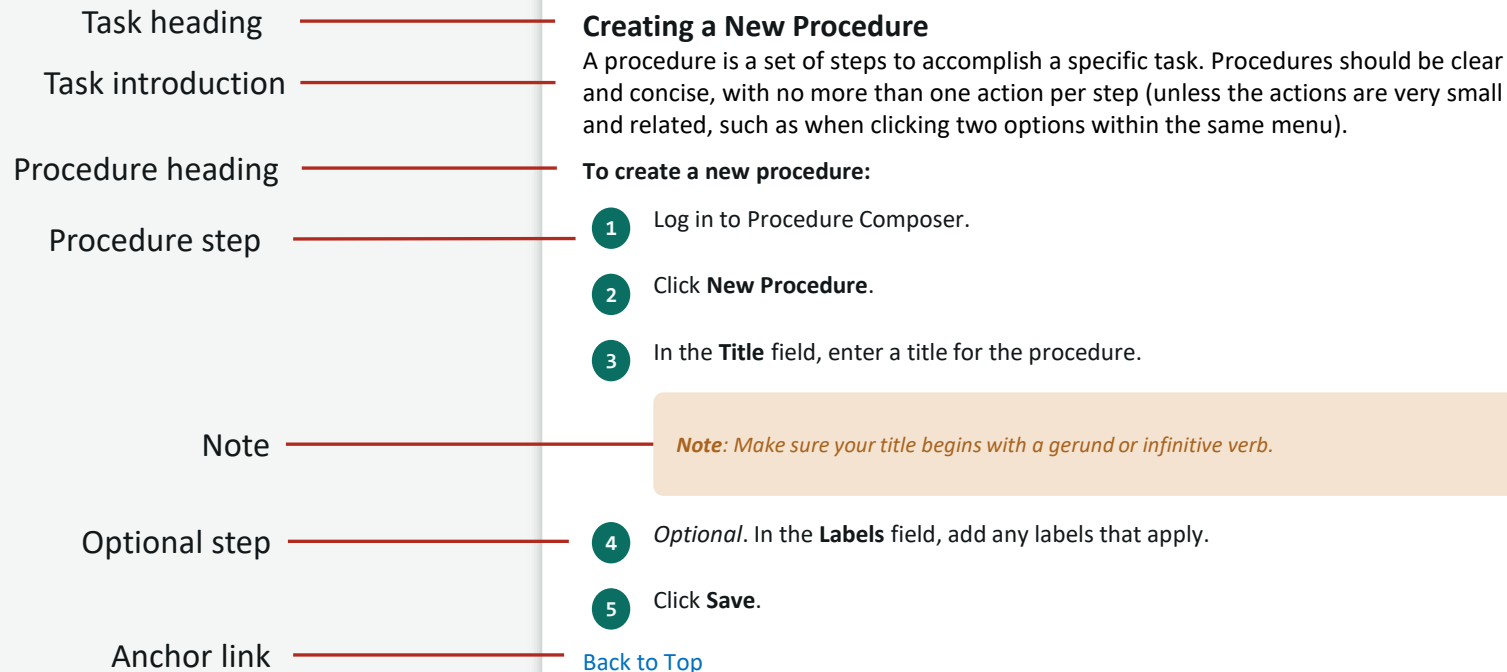
Definition of a procedure

“A procedure is a short description of the steps a user takes to complete a specific task.”

– Microsoft Manual of Style for Technical Publications, 3rd Edition

Note the 1:1 relationship between a task and a procedure.

Anatomy of a procedure



Task headings



Do

- Start with a gerund or infinitive verb form.
- Use title case or sentence case (defer to your style guide).
- Keep headings as short as possible to keep your mini table of contents clean.



Don't

- Start with “How to.”
- Capitalize articles or prepositions.
- Add colons to the heading.

Introductions



Do

- Provide necessary context and define new or obscure terms.
- Spell out acronyms the first time they're used.
- Explain why the procedure is useful or give an example of its purpose.
- Core principle: new hires need it, and every page is page one.



Don't

- Repeat anything that will be clearly described or implied in the procedure.
- Assume readers know what you mean by a given term or acronym.

Procedure headings



Do

- Use bold formatting.
- Use an infinitive verb phrase at the beginning.
- Add a colon at the end.
- Match the procedure title (except for the opening verb).



Don't

- Use italics or a heading style.
- Omit the procedure heading if there's no introduction — unless your style guide says otherwise.

Steps, part 1



Do

- Use numbered lists to imply sequence.
- Start each step with an active verb.
- Bold terms that refer to sections or clickable elements of the interface.
- Use locators to show where in the interface an action happens (but avoid locator overload).
- Add a “feedback statement” only if it clarifies the action. Be sparing, or let the locator imply it.
- Add a period at the end of each step.



Don't

- Bury the action in the middle of a long sentence.
- Mix multiple unrelated actions into a single step.

Steps, part 2

● Do

- Use “Do one of the following:” to handle if-then situations.
- Add an expand or disclosure beneath a step for extra detail, if necessary.
- Repeat common steps across procedures for parallelism.
- Precede a step with *Optional*. if it isn't required.

● Don't

- Use carets (>) for menu paths unless the audience is internal and the meaning is very clear. The caret symbol is generally bad for localization.
- Cram more than one primary action into a single numbered step.

Images & advanced formatting

● Do

- Use images sparingly, placed directly under the applicable step and aligned with the first letter of the first word.
- Use a drop-shadow effect for screenshots.
- Use alignment and proximity to connect an image to its step.
- Use your tool's built-in callout styles rather than one-off formatting.

● Don't

- Use tables to organize everything.
- Insert an image, note, or other element where it's unclear which step it applies to.

Branches or forks

Common scenarios

- Variations depending on the user's role
- Multiple ways to do the same thing

Tactics

- A preliminary procedure that branches into the rest
- “Do one of the following” followed by bullets
- “Do one of the following” followed by a table
- A “You can also...” callout

Resources

- Microsoft Manual of Style for Technical Publications, 3rd Edition — p. 117–124, “Procedures.”



Questions?

Procedure Writing Workshop — Richard Rabil